AI FOR MANAGERS

How to lead teams that use AI – without losing control

What a Completed Plan Looks Like

A worked example – one completed version of the workbook's four artifacts, built by a fictional manager with her real-world constraints, evidence gaps and all. A reference point, not a template to copy.

ASSESS

Team AI Baseline

The process layer made visible – per person and for the team

ALIGN

Team Working Standard

Five agreements and one documented workflow

CONTROL

Checkpoint Map

Three checks, each with a moment and an owner

LEAD

Lead AI Adoption Plan

The four roles in operation, on a rhythm

THE SITUATION

Leila's team

This is one completed version of the workbook's outputs — the four artifacts you build as you work through the exercises. It's a reference point, not a template to copy. Do the exercises with your own team, and your artifacts will look something like this, built from your reality rather than Leila's.

The point isn't the detail of her answers. It's what each artifact gives a manager once it exists — and what "done properly" actually looks like, imperfections included.

THE STARTING POINT

Leila manages a six-person marketing and content team at a professional services firm — content briefs, campaign proposals, client reports, internal strategy docs. Most of it reaches clients or senior stakeholders. Three of her six use AI regularly, two barely touch it, one is in between. Her company issued an AI policy six weeks ago that nobody has really applied. Leadership wants evidence that AI is improving quality and turnaround — and Leila doesn't have the visibility to answer. She works through the plan after finishing the course.

ASSESS · ARTIFACT 1

Team AI Baseline

WHAT SHE DID

She started with herself – her own tools, tasks, and risks – then ran the AI Baseline Assessment with each person across Usage, Impact, Capability, and Risk. She framed it as an invitation, not an audit, and opened by sharing one of her own messy AI moments so people knew it was safe to be honest.

The output – her Team AI Baseline

Rating: ●○○ limited · ●●○ developing · ●●● strong

Person	Usage	Impact	Capability	Risk	Notes
Aisha	●●●	●●●	●●○	●○○	Wide use, strong drafts – but thin on explaining her recommendation logic, and rarely checks figures before sending
Bram	●●○	●●○	●●○	●●○	Regular use on reports; describes his process only in generic terms
Carlos	●○○	–	–	–	*Evidence gap – little visible use, and the first conversation didn't give a clear read. Needs another look*
Diana	●●○	●○○	●○○	●●○	Tried AI for briefing synthesis; three attempts didn't work and her confidence is dropping
Eva	●●●	●●○	●●●	●●○	Independent experimenter; has one finding that looks worth spreading
Frank	●●○	●●○	●●○	●○○	Fast output, little visible checking before work moves on
Team	●●○	●●○	●●○	●○○	**Risk is the weakest column – that's where she's most exposed right now**

WHAT IT GIVES HER

For the first time she can see the *process layer*, not just the finished work – who's actually building capability, who's leaning on the tool, and where sensitive data could be walking into a prompt. The lowest-scoring column tells her exactly where to point the next move.

WHAT MAKES IT STRONG

It's a *current read, not a performance rating*. The gap on Carlos isn't a failure to fill a box – it's a named finding with a next step, which is what an honest baseline looks like.

ALIGN · ARTIFACT 2

Team Working Standard

WHAT SHE DID

She ran a collaborative session – sharing the Baseline patterns, then building the agreements with the team rather than handing them down. She then mapped the one workflow where the stakes were highest.

The output, part 1 – the Five Agreements

1 Tools

Microsoft Copilot for M365 is approved for client and team work. Personal ChatGPT or Claude accounts are for personal experimentation only – nothing work-related. Anyone wanting to try a new tool raises it with Leila first.

2 Data

No client names, contract details, budget figures, or anything that identifies an engagement goes into AI tools. Anonymise first – "Client A," numbers removed. When in doubt, leave it out.

3 Review

Anything going to a client or senior stakeholder gets a second person's read before it leaves the team – content, not just spelling. Internal drafts are your own judgment call.

4 Disclosure

Tell Leila when AI produced a significant part of something she's reviewing – especially client-facing work – so she knows what she's actually evaluating.

5 Direction and Support

We use AI to get to the thinking faster, so we spend more time on the client judgment that differentiates our work. Writing and analytical judgment stay strong. Everyone gets time and peer support to build confidence.

The output, part 2 – one documented workflow: Client report production

Question	How it runs
What starts the task	A completed client engagement; the analyst pulls findings into a report
Where AI enters	Drafting the executive summary and tightening sections from the analyst's own notes, in Copilot
What information it uses	The analyst's written notes and anonymised data – no client names or raw financials pasted in

What it produces	A draft executive summary and cleaned-up report sections
Where human judgment / verification happens	Every figure in the summary is checked against the source analysis; a second team member reads the full report
Who remains accountable	The analyst owns the report; Leila signs off client-facing release

A second workflow — content briefs — is documented separately. Shown here is the higher-stakes one.

WHAT IT GIVES HER

The work that matters most now has a shared shape. Six people stop producing client reports six different ways, and the agreements turn "use AI sensibly" into something concrete enough to actually follow.

WHAT MAKES IT STRONG

It documents how the work *actually* runs and names where judgment and verification live — not an aspirational redesign nobody keeps to.

CONTROL · ARTIFACT 3

Checkpoint Map

WHAT SHE DID

She took the three risk moments the course named — AI reaching a decision, data going in, and work going out — and placed a simple check at each moment risk could reach a consequence.

The output — her Checkpoint Map

When — the moment	What gets checked	Who
Before an AI-assisted executive summary goes to client review	Every figure verified against the source analysis	The analyst who wrote it
Before pasting source material into Copilot for a report	Confirm it's anonymised — no client names or identifying numbers	The analyst
Before any AI-assisted work goes to a client or senior stakeholder	A second person reads the content, not just proofs it	A second team member

ONE MANAGED UNKNOWN

Company policy is unclear on whether client call transcripts may go into the approved tool. Leila doesn't guess and doesn't leave "check policy" in the plan — she's put the specific workflow-and-data question to Marta in Security, with an answer expected by Friday. Until it's confirmed, transcripts stay out.

WHAT IT GIVES HER

The risks she could only *see* in the Baseline are now *controlled* — each one has a named moment and a named owner, instead of depending on someone happening to remember.

WHAT MAKES IT STRONG

The checks are simple enough to actually happen (each under two minutes), every one has an owner, and the question she can't answer yet is *managed with a next step* — not left hanging.

LEAD · ARTIFACT 4

Lead AI Adoption Plan

WHAT SHE DID

She brought the four roles into operation – Reinforce and Develop were already underway from earlier, and she switched on Amplify and Scout.

> **Reinforce**
>
> Scanning the four levers, Recognition was her weakest – she praises results but rarely the *how*. This week she'll name, in the team meeting, that Aisha caught a figure error before a client briefing went out. Direction language she'll keep repeating: *"We use AI to get to the thinking faster, so we spend more time on the judgment that differentiates our work."* And the longer view she'll start saying out loud: over the next year, AI improving not just drafts, but how the team researches, plans, and delivers its campaigns.

Develop – move each person from where they actually are

Person	Where they are	Evidence	Next step	Follow-up
Aisha	Exploring	Wide use, but weak at explaining her recommendation logic	Process review: what she accepted, changed, or rejected, and why	Next 1:1
Bram	Complying	Regular use, generic process descriptions	One report task where he must state the key judgment call	After the report
Carlos	*Not yet placed*	First conversation didn't give a clear read	Observe one suitable task, then revisit	2 weeks
Diana	Struggling	Three unsuccessful attempts, confidence dropping	Pair with Eva on one real attempt for 20 minutes	1 week later
Eva	Exploring	Independent experiments, one transferable finding	Bring that finding to the shared learning discussion	Next review
Frank	Complying	Fast output, little visible checking	Same judgment-visible task structure as Bram	After the task

Amplify

The learning question gets a recurring home in the monthly campaign review: *"Has anyone learned something about using AI since we last asked – something that worked, something that didn't, something worth sharing?"* First finding to spread: Eva's research approach – Eva will walk it through in the next campaign review. Leila answers first herself, with a stakeholder summary that *didn't* work and what she changed.

Scout

Running the scan, one opportunity stood out: pulling together market and competitor research before a campaign proposal eats hours before the real thinking even starts – and it's exactly where they've lost ground to faster competitors. She put it through the two questions. *Would fixing it genuinely help?* Yes – it's a recurring time cost on high-value work that leadership is watching. *Would the gain be worth the setup and ongoing checking?* Likely, as long as quality holds. Decision: run a bounded trial – its own small project, set up after the review, with an owner and an end date: use AI to assemble the market and competitor research pack before drafting starts, something the team hasn't tried yet, across the next two proposals, with the bar set up front (turnaround drops without the insight getting thinner). Then decide whether it becomes standard.

A "hold," or "nothing worth pursuing yet," would have been an equally valid outcome – the discipline is in the two questions, not in always finding something.

Quarterly review booked

About three months after Lead goes live, 60 minutes, whole team.

WHAT IT GIVES HER

Adoption stops depending on individual enthusiasm. She has a per-person next move, a way for one person's discovery to reach everyone, and a deliberate look for what's worth doing next – all on a rhythm that keeps it alive.

WHAT MAKES IT STRONG

It's *evidence-based, not artificially complete*. Carlos is still an open evidence gap, and some practices are only just starting. Where she has evidence she acts – Scout moves to a bounded trial; where she doesn't, she names the gap and the next move instead of forcing certainty. Success isn't every box ticked – it's that the current state and the next move are visible.

WHAT THIS ISN'T

The starting structure, not the finished state

Carlos may not open up in the first conversation. The Align session might surface a third workflow. The quarterly review will raise things the plan didn't anticipate. That's the plan *working* — surfacing what's actually true rather than what was assumed.

YOUR VERSION

Do the exercises with your own team, and you'll have your own version of this: four artifacts that turn AI in your team into something you manage, rather than something you hope works out.